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Universal Indifference Regarding Uplifting the Impoverished

The human experience is thought to be one which is unique, made only further different by the places around the world. The stories *The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas* and *The Garden Party* look to highlight these differences, showing the disparity in lifestyle that exists between groups of people residing in a shared space. By doing this, the stories also denote the similarities that these prideful individuals have in common, particularly their good fortunes which lend to a higher quality of life. The residents of Omelas are in a constant state of happiness and contempt, and the Sheridans are treated to the finer aspects of life due to their wealth. These two different groups each seem perfect in their own respects, and void of the misery that plagues the common person. However, existing just on the fringe of both of these worlds lay an ugly reminder of the necessary contrast life must have for someone to experience happiness. Everyone existing in these utopias are aware of this fact, but tend to try and ignore the truth and instead live inside their bubble. Humanity is driven by a set of common goals, and although everyone's version of success looks different, very few tend to look at a life of misery willingly, and even less want to help any other people but themselves.

The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas revolves around describing the fictional city of Omelas, and particularly how perfect of a life its people seem to live. Sentences such as “They were not simple folk, you see, though they were happy”(Le Guin 127) and “Happiness is based on a just discrimination of what is necessary, what is neither necessary nor destructive, and what is is

destructive”(Le Guin 128) help to shape what make the lives of the Omelas near flawless. They’re contemptuous with the lives they live, and don’t require the superficial to bring themselves joy. Omelas is also said to be void of ideas and items which hinder one's happiness. “One thing I know there is none of in Omelas is guilt”(Le Guin 129). It’s the absence of both synthetic and natural want’s which allow for such universal happiness. The Sheridan family in *The Garden Party* operates differently in where they find pleasure, yet still experience this unwavering happiness. Although never explicitly stated, the Sheridans are suggested to be of a higher class due to their material possessions and unessential amenities that are mentioned throughout the story, such as their large flower-filled garden, tennis court, and overall size of vacant land which is big enough for a marquee. This type of happiness is different from the one experienced by those living in Omelas. All of these goods can be taken away at a moment's notice, and their presence is necessary to keep happiness in the Sheridan’s lives. Regardless of what brings joy to these people, it’s shown that there's a universality in wanting a stasis of happiness. To understand what happiness is, one must also know what sadness feels like, and living just outside the outskirts of these fortunate individuals lives are others living with this sadness, forced to dwell in this emotion for so long that the feeling is as normal to them as happiness is to those living in Omelas and the Sheridans.

Located behind a locked door in the basement of a building in Omelas lives a child of no definitive age nor gender. This child is malnourished, mistreated, and entirely isolated from society, with members of Omelas coming only to look at this child, but never to interact with them. This child is explained to be the reason why those living in Omela can experience eternal happiness, as the happiness is dependent “wholly on this child’s abominable misery”(Le Guin 130). This child is not allowed to be freed or treated well, as doing so would cause “all the

prosperity and beauty and delight of Omelas [to] wither and be destroyed”(Le Guin 131). This child acts as a personification of the ugly truth of happiness. Something which suffers with sadness must exist to create those who can be happy. In *The Garden Party*, the Sheridan household neighbours a slumish road filled with poor, impoverished cottages that “had no right to be in that neighbourhood at all”(Mansfield 79). A family who lives in these homes, known as the Scott’s, suffers the death of the father of their household, his death occurring the morning of the Sheridan’s garden party. Instead of postponing the party to show their condolences, the party continues as normal, with the only act of sympathy towards the family being a gift basket of sandwich scraps from the party being brought to the family by Laura Sheridan, the main character of the story and one of the families younger members. This small, poor section of the neighbourhood plays a similar role in the lives of the Sheridan’s as the child does to those who live in Omelas, with a less fortunate entity being purposefully ignored and looked down upon to bring more happiness to one's own life. Both groups are more concerned about themselves rather than lifting others up with them, yet there exist a small number of people who try and break this mold by trying to distance themselves from the situation, or at the very least being mindful that there exists lives outside of their own which are much less fortunate, and don’t contain the frequent opportunities to experience happiness.

A strong desire for change or separation from an item or idea must exist for one to take action. This holds especially true in the case of these two stories, with those who desire reform coming from highly thought after situations, namely being from Omelas or a member of the Sheridan family. In Omelas, a happy child may see the one who has been locked inside of the basement and be reduced to tears and anger, confused and angered of why they are being treated this way. Once the child’s sacrifice is explained, this frustration begins to taper off, largely due to the

helplessness they now share with the child, knowing this sacrifice could be freed, but doing so would do much more harm than good. Some never get over seeing this locked up child, and simply leave Omelas altogether. The guilt of knowing this child's sacrifice, and how they and many others benefit from it is too much to bear, so these people simply leave Omelas to a place "less imaginable to most of us than the city of happiness"(Le Guin 132). Members of the Sheridan family do not practice the same reflection that those in Omelas do, opting to try their best to forget about the poor family who live just down the road from their own house. Laura appears to be the only one who houses the sympathy some in Omelas have, wanting to stop the garden party upon hearing of Mr. Scott's death and succumbing to tears after being exposed to the lives of those in the poor area of the neighborhood. The tears are not shed in fear, but for admiration of life's beauty, and how these families continue to keep pushing, regardless of the quality of life they are given. The parallels existing between these two stories show that when people are contemptuous with their situation alone, they never want change, even if it means helping others in need. Only rarely do people ever try to take action, as it's easier and safer to maintain the societal equilibrium that has been established.

Although the stories of *The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas* and *The Garden Party* take place in different locations under unique circumstances, they help to demonstrate the generality of this specific human experience. Both stories document groups of characters living a privileged life, and are well aware of people who are less fortunate living near them, yet a conscious ignorance is practiced to eliminate guilty feelings which could tarnish their perfect lives. Those living in Omelas could help the child in the basement, but doing so would break apart the utopia being maintained by the imbalance of this child's suffering, so no attempt is ever made, putting the importance of the many over the equal treatment of all. The Sheridans have nothing stopping

them from being more caring and helpful to families like the Scott's, yet an attempt is never made to save them from their "poky little holes"(Mansfield 80). Once human's get to experience utopia, they will do whatever they can to stay there, and rarely do they consider bringing anybody with them at risk of ruining the perfect life which was made for them.

Works Cited

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